

The Gion Festival through the Lens of *Rakuchū Rakugai Zu* and Contemporary Anime

Every July, the streets of Kyoto transform as towering *yamaboko* (floats), some weighing up to twelve tons and adorned with centuries-old tapestries, are pulled through the city's downtown in the Gion Festival procession. The festival traces its origins to 869 CE, when purification rites were performed at Yasaka Shrine to appease vengeful spirits believed to have caused a devastating plague during the dangerous summer months. Over a millennium later, the seasonal logic endures: the festival still arrives with the heat and humidity, the floats still purify the streets, and residents still hang amulets on their doorways to ward off disease and misfortune. Yet the ways people see, depict, and engage with this seasonal ritual have shifted considerably. Sixteenth-century *rakuchū rakugai zu* (scenes in and around the capital) folding screens embedded the Gion Festival within politically charged panoramas, depicting the procession alongside shogunal (military government) residences and imperial palaces. By the seventeenth century, these representations shifted toward genre painting, treating the festival as popular spectacle independent of political meaning.¹ In the present day, both contemporary celebrations and anime carry the festival's seasonal imagery to audiences far beyond Kyoto, transmitting its ritual logic through lived experience and the language of entertainment alike. This paper argues that while Gion Festival's visual culture has been continuously reimagined across media and centuries—the underlying seasonal impulse at its core, the need to collectively mark the passage

¹ Matthew Philip McKelway, *Capitalscapes: Folding Screens and Political Imagination in Late Medieval Kyoto* (University of Hawai'i Press, 2006), 198–199.

of summer and to ritually protect the community during its most vulnerable months—has remained remarkably unchanged. What has changed is not the ritual’s core itself but the surfaces on which it is rendered and the relationship between viewer and sacred event. Tracing this evolution matters because it reveals how communities sustain shared meaning through visual culture even as the political, technological, and spiritual contexts surrounding their rituals are fundamentally transformed.

The Gion Festival has been celebrated every summer in Kyoto for nearly twelve centuries, making it one of the longest continuously observed seasonal rituals in Japanese history.² July in Kyoto is hot and humid, and the festival nearly coincides with the end of the rainy season, tying its timing to a moment of seasonal transition.³ Since its origins, the festival’s core purpose has been to pacify the malevolent spirits believed to cause epidemic disease. The Gion cult, a system of worship centered on a shrine-temple complex in Kyoto, grew out of this event, bringing together disparate myths, rituals, and symbols in the ninth and tenth centuries into a formalized annual ceremony: *goryō-e* (purification ceremonies designed to ward off plague-causing spirits).⁴ Despite this longevity, the festival’s history was periodically interrupted. During the Muromachi period (1336–1573), decades of civil war, including the devastating Ōnin War (1467–1477), led to frequent cancellations. The festival’s survival depended on the financial commitment of Kyoto’s merchant neighborhoods. It was under the long peace of the Edo period (1603–1868), when economic prosperity and political stability allowed the festival to become reliably annual. Under these conditions, the *yamaboko* grew into the elaborate, textile-laden mobile art objects recognized today. The visual representations of the festival across these

² Elisabetta Porcu, “The Gion Festival in Kyoto and Glocalization,” *Religions* 13, no. 8 (2022): 689.

³ Porcu, “Gion Festival and Glocalization,” 689.

⁴ Neil McMullin, “On Placating the Gods and Pacifying the Populace: The Case of the Gion ‘Goryō’ Cult,” *History of Religions* 27, no. 3 (1988): 271.

periods register these shifts in political circumstance while preserving the underlying seasonal structure.

The *rakuchū rakugai zu* genre, of which roughly fifty examples survive in Western collections and over one hundred and fifty in Japan, spanning the sixteenth through eighteenth centuries, offers one of the richest visual archives for tracing these shifts. These folding screens typically come in pairs, each consisting of six panels depicting a different scene of life in and around the capital. The earliest surviving version is the Uesugi version (1560s), painted by Kanō Eitoku (1543–1590) (fig. 1.1). The right screen depicts the Shimogyō (lower capital) area and the left screen the Kamigyō (upper capital). This pair has traditionally been understood as a political gift from the warlord Oda Nobunaga (1534–1582) to his last remaining rival Uesugi Kenshin (1530–1578), a reading that casts them as instruments of diplomacy between powerful men competing for control of a war-torn capital.⁵ Commissioning and giving such a painting were itself a social ritual: a gesture that asserted cultural authority, territorial dominance, and political stability all at once. To give someone a panoramic vision of a functioning, festival-filled Kyoto was to claim mastery over that vision. However, recent scholarship complicates this interpretation. Matthew McKelway argues that the screens reflect something more complex than a simple, straightforward warlord-as-patron relationship.⁶ The choices about what to depict and how to depict it were informed by an understanding of Kyoto's own internal politics, charting sociopolitical networks and physical changes within the capital that spoke to the interests of those within the city as much as those outside it.⁷ The Gion Festival's prominent placement in

⁵ McKelway, *Capitalscapes*, 3.

⁶ Ibid.

⁷ Ibid.

the composition represents not only a signal to distant rivals but a reflection of how Kyoto understood its own seasonal and civic identity.

On the surface, the right screen reads as a political document. New Year celebrations at the Imperial Palace dominate the left edge of the Shimogyō screen, its white gravel courtyard and cypress-thatched halls rendered as the largest single motif in the entire composition.⁸ The Gion Festival procession occupies the center, but it is surrounded by a constellation of landmarks that signal authority and sacred power. Yasaka Shrine sits prominently near the top of the screen. The distinctive pagoda of Hokanji Temple rises above the surrounding rooftops. Temple compounds with blue-tiled roofs punctuate the hillside. The screens present a city full of celebrations and life, a Kyoto that looks vibrant and joyful. But this vibrancy is an idealization. Many of these sites are depicted in exaggerated and perfected states. Tōji's pagoda, for example, rises as the tallest structure in the composition, though it may not have been standing when Eitoku painted the screens, since it had been struck by lightning in 1563.⁹ The gold clouds reinforce this curated vision, selectively revealing landmarks that serve the political message while concealing everything else behind elegant golden emptiness, guiding the viewer's eye between sites of political and religious significance. The festival procession passes over a bridge spanning the river, but the river does not dominate the composition; it serves as one geographic marker among many in what reads as an idealized map of the capital (fig. 1.2). McKelway observes that "if the dignified elegance of the Imperial Palace is the center of gravity in the Shimogyō screen, the diffuse energy of the Gion Festival acts as its foil."¹⁰ The two anchor the composition in a tension between static political authority on one side and dynamic seasonal

⁸ McKelway, *Capitalscapes*, 106.

⁹ McKelway, *Capitalscapes*, 112.

¹⁰ McKelway, *Capitalscapes*, 110.

energy on the other. In the turbulent 1560s, when civil war and financial instability led to the festival's frequent cancellation, the Uesugi screens offered not a record of Kyoto but a vision of what Kyoto ought to be.

Yet beneath this political surface lies a deeper seasonal order. The panels trace the passage of the twelve months, with spring and summer in the Shimogyō screen and autumn and winter in the Kamigyō screen.¹¹ In the Shimogyō screen, this progression runs from New Year's ceremonies at the Imperial Palace to the sixth-month Gion Festival, compressing half a year into a single surface. Given the sheer size of the *rakuchū rakugai zu*, viewers seated between the paired screens in an intimate or social gathering would have been immersed in the illusion of Kyoto's full annual cycle, not simply observing the seasons but inhabiting them. Within this temporal structure, the Gion Festival is the only festival depicted at such scale, the event to which the whole of summer builds. The political framing of the Uesugi screens is clear and deliberate, but their deepest organizing principle is not power but the passage of the seasons. However one reads the composition's networks of power, the Gion Festival remains inseparable from that seasonal core.

The *rakuchū rakugai zu* held at the Metropolitan Museum of Art, dating to the seventeenth century under Tokugawa rule, presents a markedly different vision of the festival and the city that hosts it (fig. 2.1). Where the Uesugi screens depicted Kyoto as a political idea, the Met screens depict it as a lived place. By the seventeenth century, Japan had achieved peace and stabilization under Tokugawa rule, and the *rakuchū rakugai zu* screens had evolved from diplomatic instruments into something closer to dowry items and cultural souvenirs, prized gifts for visitors to take back from the capital.¹² The Met pair separates Kyoto into east and west

¹¹ McKelway, *Capitalscapes*, 47.

¹² McKelway, *Capitalscapes*, 2.

rather than upper and lower capital, with Nijō Castle, the shogun's Kyoto residence, anchoring the left screen and the Gion Festival dominating the street activity of the right. The festival has become the main visual event of its screen.

The composition is denser with architecture and activity than its Uesugi counterpart, filled with residential buildings, merchant shops, and the texture of everyday urban life. The gold clouds recede, giving way to a more fully and realistically populated cityscape. The surrounding architecture is no longer a catalog of political landmarks but a fabric of ordinary city life. Though advances in painting technique may account for some of this increased detail, the close-up in fig. 2.2 reveals a deeper shift in artistic intent. The *yamaboko* are rendered in vivid detail: their tapestries are more colorful, and their textures are more carefully distinguished than in the Uesugi version, with floral motifs adorning their surfaces. The *yamaboko* are crowned with *naginata* (long spear-like halberds) rising above the rooftops. Figures seated atop the floats wear richly patterned garments, while participants in traditional samurai armor process beside and behind them, likely not as displays of military power but as forms of ceremonial pageantry, a communal performance of shared cultural memory. Where the Uesugi screens, viewed more from above, subordinate the floats to the political landscape around them, the Met screens treat them as artistic objects worthy of close attention, giving space to their textiles, iconography, and decorative richness. The river also assumes a more prominent presence in this composition, its waters flowing visibly near the festival activity, perhaps evoking the purification rituals at the heart of the Gion tradition, in which *mikoshi* (sacred portable shrines) are cleansed with water from the Kamo River. The overall effect is one of popular spectacle, though the screens may still carry a quieter political message, presenting not control over a contested capital but confidence in an era of peace and prosperity.

The visual shift from the Uesugi to the Met screens reflects a change in who viewed these works and what they sought in them. Painted by one of the most prestigious artists of the age for warlords competing for political dominance, the Uesugi screens invited an elite viewer to read them for political meaning. The Met screens reflect a different kind of interest: not political legibility but a broader cultural curiosity, perhaps among wealthy merchants, visiting dignitaries, or foreigners seeing the capital for the first time. Where the Uesugi screens present Kyoto as a political idea, the Met screens present it as a lived place, a city worth knowing for its own sake. The festival was no longer primarily a claim about order but an object of appreciation in itself. The social practice of viewing shifted accordingly. It was no longer an act of tracing political networks, but of taking pleasure in the textures of urban life. The screens themselves became social objects: works to display, gift, and enjoy, valued for the vision of communal life they preserved.

The Met screens find a parallel in written records from the period. Seventeenth-century accounts of Kyoto's annual ceremonies show that the city's year was structured by a dense cycle of seasonal rituals observed across social classes.¹³ Even the poorest Kyoto townspeople, Gerald Groemer notes, "would not have allowed the four seasons to elapse without celebrating" the major calendrical occasions.¹⁴ Though this claim may carry some exaggeration, it still suggests a society deeply shaped by ritual observance. The Gion Festival was one node in a broader summer rhythm that included *hassaku* (a day of seasonal gift-giving and formal greetings) on the first day of the eighth month and the "Releasing of Life Ritual" at Iwashimizu Hachiman Shrine on the fifteenth. As part of this annual cycle, the festival gave shape and meaning to communal

¹³ Gerald Groemer, *A Year in Seventeenth-Century Kyoto: Edo-Period Writings on Annual Ceremonies, Festivals, and Customs* (University of Hawaii Press, 2022), 35.

¹⁴ Groemer, *A Year in Seventeenth-Century Kyoto*, 37.

life in the capital. The *rakuchū rakugai zu* screens, in depicting the festival, were therefore depicting not just a single event but a larger system of seasonal consciousness, one in which each month carried its own rituals, obligations, and communal meaning.

Contemporary anime extends the transmission of the Gion Festival's seasonal meaning into an entirely new medium, one that would be unrecognizable to the painters of the *rakuchū rakugai zu* screens yet serves a remarkably similar function. In *Deaimon* (2022), a slice-of-life anime centered on a traditional Kyoto confectionery shop and the makeshift family that forms around it, the festival appears not as a political statement or an ethnographic document but as a lived seasonal rhythm woven into the characters' daily lives in Kyoto (figs. 3–4). Episode 3 opens with familiar festival elements: the sounds of Gion *bayashi* (traditional festival music), vividly colored *yamaboko*, crowds in *yukata* (light summer kimono), and the lantern-lit streets of *yoiyama* (the festive evenings preceding the procession). These images embed the festival within a story about family, trust, and the seasonal cadence of life in Kyoto.

The anime's visual treatment of the *yamaboko* oscillates between intimacy and spectacle. In one shot, the camera lingers on the close-up detail of a float's tapestry, its red and gold surface depicting dragons amid swirling clouds, with ornamental hangings (*sagari*) dangling from its lower edge (fig. 3). The level of attention to the textile's surface recalls the detailed rendering of float decoration in the seventeenth-century *rakuchū rakugai zu*, where the *yamaboko*'s iconographic programs had become objects of visual interest in their own right. In another shot, the camera pulls back to a wide street-level view of *yoiyama*: the lantern-lit float glowing against a twilight sky as crowds fill the summer street (fig. 4). The same *naginata* halberds that crown the floats in the Met *rakuchū rakugai zu* rise here above the rooftops in animated form, a visual

feature that has survived almost unchanged from seventeenth-century painted screens to twenty-first-century animation.

This wider perspective also captures the festival's embodied and communal atmosphere: the heat and humidity of Kyoto in July, the press of the crowd, and the sensory density of the summer street.¹⁵ The month begins with *kippu-iri*, the formal opening ceremony, and closes with *nagoshi no harae*, a summer purification ritual in which visitors pass through a sacred reed wreath and purchase protective amulets to hang at their doorways.¹⁶ As Jolyon Thomas argues, this casual deployment of religious and ritual imagery in anime is not without consequence. Even when audiences do not consciously register the religious dimensions of what they are watching, they absorb traditional knowledge through entertainment: the seasonal timing of the festival, the appearance and movement of the *yamaboko*, the sounds of Gion *bayashi*, and the broader cultural logic of summer purification. Thomas notes that young Japanese people are more likely to express belief in spirits and deities than to claim allegiance to any formal religious tradition, and that they tend to describe practices like shrine visits and festival attendance as custom (*dentō*) rather than religion.¹⁷ The Gion Festival, as mediated through anime, operates in precisely this space: it transmits the seasonal and spiritual logic of a twelve-hundred-year-old purification ritual to audiences who experience it not as doctrine but as atmosphere, narrative, and visual pleasure. In Thomas's terms, the anime screen has become the newest surface on which the festival's ancient seasonal impulse is rendered, extending a process that began with painted screens and has never ceased.

¹⁵ Elisabetta Porcu, "Gion Matsuri in Kyoto: A Multilayered Religious Phenomenon," *Journal of Religion in Japan* 9, no. 1–3 (2020): 53–54.

¹⁶ Porcu, "Gion Matsuri in Kyoto," 58.

¹⁷ Jolyon Baraka Thomas, *Drawing on Tradition: Manga, Anime, and Religion in Contemporary Japan* (University of Hawai'i Press, 2012), 10.

Thomas's concept of *shūkyō asobi* (religious play) offers a framework for understanding not only anime's relationship to the Gion Festival but the festival's own history.¹⁸ Throughout its twelve centuries of existence, the Gion Festival has always occupied the space where participants see themselves as audience members and consumers as much as believers. The Edo period townspeople depicted in the *rakuchū rakugai zu* screens were already spectators of a ritual they experienced as entertainment as much as purification. Contemporary festivalgoers who purchase *chimaki* (protective straw amulets), eat street food during *yoiyama*, and photograph the *yamaboko* continue to engage in what Thomas calls "ritualized behavior including the acquisition of worldly benefits and ludic activities," whether or not they would describe their participation as religious.¹⁹ Anime viewers are simply the latest extension of this pattern. They encounter the festival through screens, absorbing its ritual logic as atmosphere and narrative rather than doctrine. What the *rakuchū rakugai zu* screens, the festival itself, and contemporary anime share is this fusion of play and ritual, entertainment and the sacred, that has defined the Gion Festival from its origins as a communal response to the dangers of summer.

In sum, the Gion Festival has been rendered on many surfaces across its twelve-century history: on gold-leafed folding screens commissioned by warlords, on the bustling streets of a peacetime merchant capital, on the sweat-soaked bodies of contemporary festivalgoers standing in the July heat, and on the animated screens of a Kyoto-set anime watched from a living room thousands of miles away. Each surface has shaped how the festival is seen, understood, and felt. The Uesugi screens of the 1560s asked viewers to read the festival as evidence of an idealized, stable capital, a political vision of what Kyoto ought to be. The Met screens of the seventeenth

¹⁸ Jolyon Baraka Thomas, "Shūkyō Asobi and Miyazaki Hayao's Anime," *Nova Religio: The Journal of Alternative and Emergent Religions* 10, no. 3 (2007): 74.

¹⁹ Thomas, "Shūkyō Asobi," 76.

century invited them to appreciate it as cultural spectacle, the floats rendered for their own artistic richness within a city worth knowing for its own sake. The embodied experience of the contemporary festival immerses participants in its sensory and ritual logic. And anime transmits its seasonal atmosphere to audiences who may never pass through a *chinowa* (large grass wreath) or hear *Gion bayashi* in person, yet who absorb the festival's ancient rhythms through the language of entertainment. However, across all these transformations, the festival's seasonal core has endured. Every July, when the heat settles over Kyoto and the *yamaboko* are assembled once more, the community enacts the same fundamental gesture it has performed since 869: gathering together to mark the passage of summer and to affirm, through shared ritual, that the dangers of the season can be collectively endured. The amulets hung on doorways, the floats pulled through the streets, the wreath of miscanthus reeds passed through at month's end: these small, repeated acts of protection and participation are what sustain the festival's meaning across centuries and across media, as well as what create its ritual space. What the visual history of the Gion Festival ultimately reveals is that seasonal rituals persist not because they remain unchanged but because they are endlessly adaptable, capable of being re-rendered on whatever surface a community finds most meaningful. The medium changes; the season, and the human need to mark it together, does not.

Bibliography

Groemer, Gerald. *A Year in Seventeenth-Century Kyoto: Edo-Period Writings on Annual Ceremonies, Festivals, and Customs*. 1st ed. University of Hawaii Press, 2022.
<https://doi.org/10.1515/9780824894658>.

Groemer translates and annotates Edo-period texts documenting Kyoto's annual cycle of ceremonies and festivals, providing a detailed picture of how seventeenth-century residents organized their lives around seasonal observances. The book demonstrates that the Gion Festival was one node in a densely structured calendar of rituals that marked the year for all social classes.

McKelway, Matthew Philip. *Capitalscapes: Folding Screens and Political Imagination in Late Medieval Kyoto*. University of Hawai'i Press, 2006.

McKelway examines *rakuchū rakugai zu*, panoramic folding screen paintings depicting scenes in and around Kyoto from the sixteenth to seventeenth centuries, analyzing how these screens were commissioned within networks of political and civic interest. He demonstrates that the screens functioned as seasonal compositions organized cyclically through the twelve months, with the Gion Festival occupying a privileged position as the climax of summer.

McMullin, Neil. "On Placating the Gods and Pacifying the Populace: The Case of the Gion 'Goryō' Cult." *History of Religions* 27, no. 3 (1988): 270–93.
<https://www.jstor.org/stable/1062279>.

McMullin examines the religious origins of the Gion cult and its connection to *goryō* (vengeful spirit) beliefs, tracing how the Gion Festival emerged from purification rituals intended to appease spirits believed to cause plague and natural disasters. The article establishes the festival's foundational link between seasonal timing and communal protection against disease.

Porcu, Elisabetta. "Gion Matsuri in Kyoto: A Multilayered Religious Phenomenon." *Journal of Religion in Japan* 9, no. 1–3 (2020): 37–77. <https://doi.org/10.1163/22118349-00901006>.
Porcu draws on ethnographic fieldwork to analyze the contemporary Gion Festival as an embodied sensory experience inseparable from its summer context. She documents the ritual frame of the month-long festival, from the opening *kippu-iri* ceremony to the closing *nagoshi no harae* purification rite, showing how the seasonal logic of the original *goryō-e* persists in present-day practice.

Porcu, Elisabetta. "The Gion Festival in Kyoto and Glocalization." *Religions* 13, no. 8 (2022): 689. <https://doi.org/10.3390/rel13080689>.

Porcu examines the Gion Festival through the lens of glocalization, exploring how the festival negotiates between local tradition and global influences. The article situates the festival within Kyoto's seasonal calendar, noting that it nearly coincides with the end of the rainy season, and analyzes how its rituals continue to function as communal responses to seasonal transition even as the festival adapts to contemporary audiences and tourism.

Thomas, Jolyon Baraka. *Drawing on Tradition: Manga, Anime, and Religion in Contemporary Japan*. University of Hawai'i Press, 2012.

Thomas examines how manga and anime deploy religious imagery and terminology, demonstrating that even casual uses of such material in entertainment media can transmit traditional knowledge to new audiences. He argues that young Japanese people absorb religious information through popular culture even when they do not identify with formal religious traditions.

Thomas, Jolyon Baraka. “Shūkyō Asobi and Miyazaki Hayao’s Anime.” *Nova Religio: The Journal of Alternative and Emergent Religions* 10, no. 3 (2007): 73–95.
<https://doi.org/10.1525/nr.2007.10.3.73>.

Thomas proposes the concept of *shūkyō asobi* (“religious play”) to describe the space where entertainment and religion overlap, particularly in anime and popular media. He argues that participants in these spaces see themselves as consumers rather than adherents, yet their engagement can still generate real spiritual responses, including ritualized behavior and moral interpretation applied to daily life.



Fig. 1.1. Kanō Eitoku, *Rakuchū rakugai zu*, Uesugi version, right screen, 1560s. Ink, color, and gold on paper, 159.2 × 361.8 cm. Yonezawa City Uesugi Museum. National Treasure. Image source: Canon Tsuzuri Project.



Fig. 1.2. Detail of fig. 1.1 showing the Gion Festival procession with *yamaboko* floats and crowds.

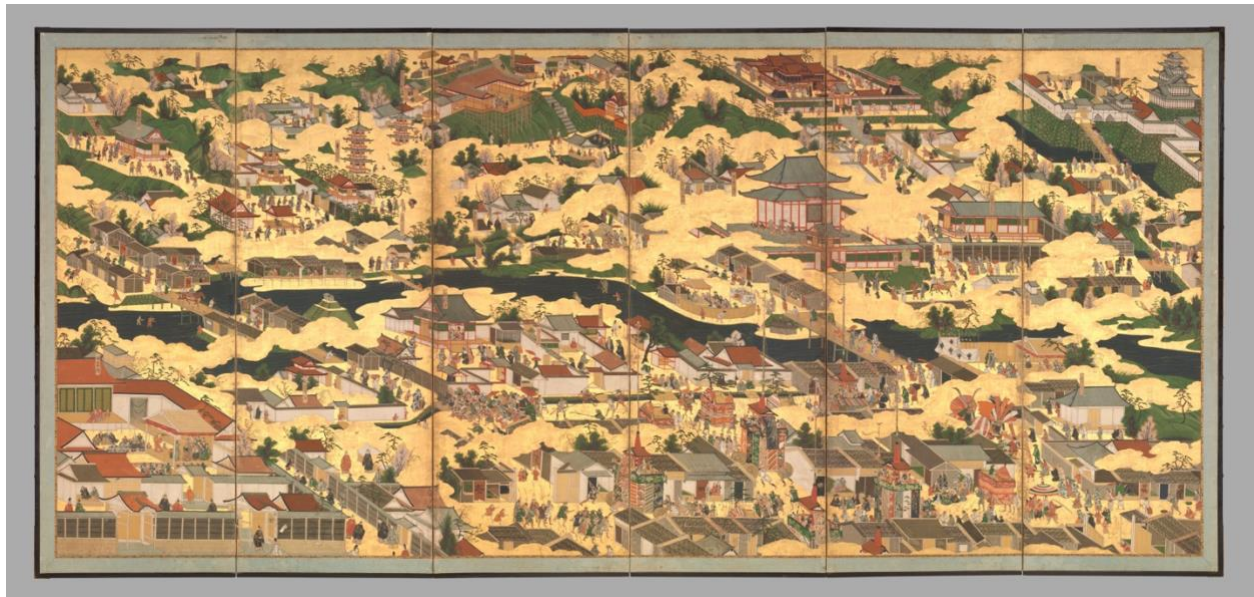


Fig. 2.1. *Rakuchū rakugai zu*, right screen, 17th century. Ink, color, gold, and gold leaf on paper, 156.1 × 352.2 cm. Metropolitan Museum of Art, New York (2015.300.106.1, .2). Public Domain.



Fig. 2.2. Detail of fig. 2.1 showing the Gion Festival procession with colorful *yamaboko* floats, figures in elaborate dress, and *naginata* halberds rising above the rooftops.



Fig. 3. Still from *Deaimon*, season 1, episode 3, directed by Fumitoshi Oizaki, 21:02. Encourage Films, 2022.

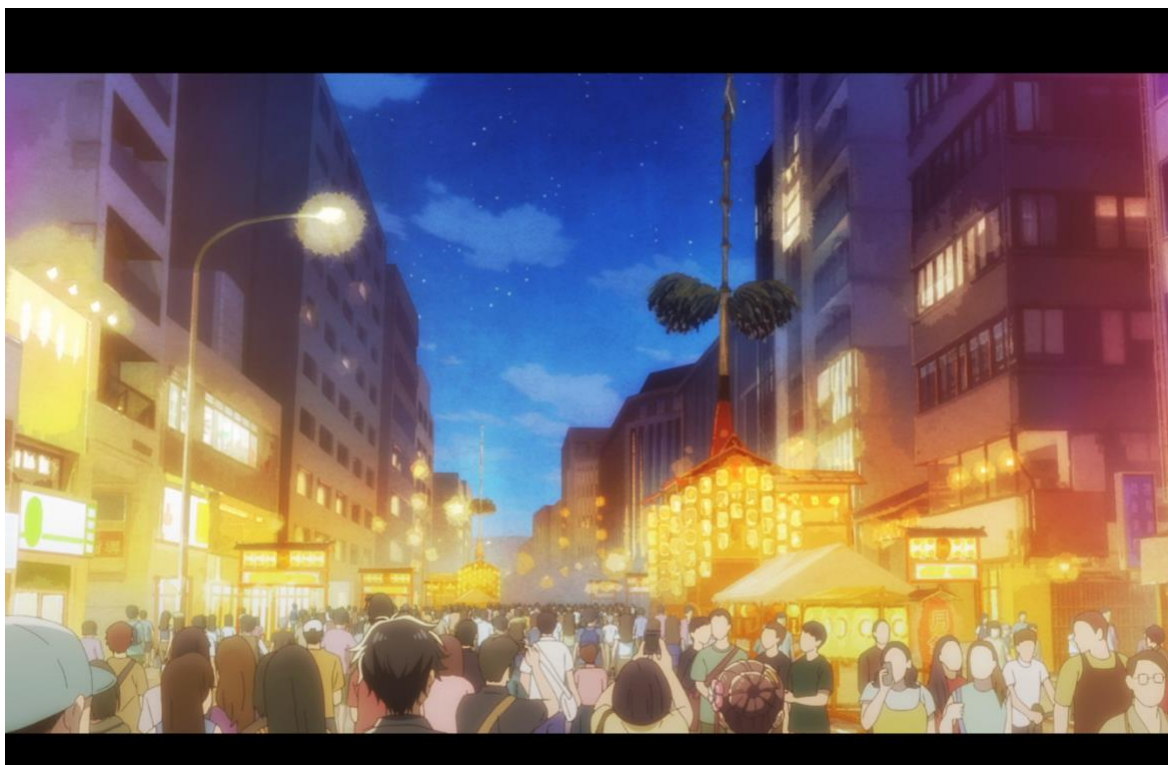


Fig. 4. Still from *Deaimon*, season 1, episode 3, directed by Fumitoshi Oizaki, 22:01. Encourage Films, 2022.